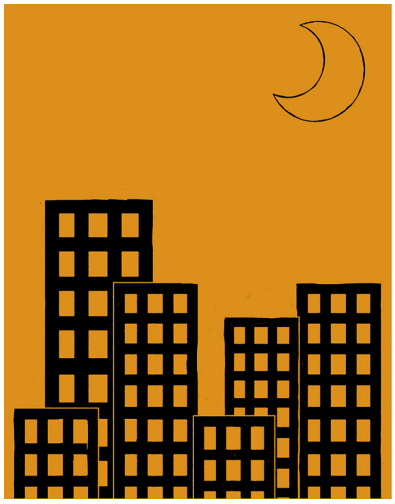


DARK SKIES ARE NOW BLOTTED OUT

LIGHT POLLUTION

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

Franz Hölker

BEFORE

1000CE The first organized system of street lighting (by oil lamps) is introduced in Muslim Spain.

1792 Scottish-born engineer William Murdock invents the gas light. Over the next half century, many cities introduce gas street lighting.

1879 American inventor Thomas Edison demonstrates the first commercially viable electric light bulb.

1976 High-brightness, high-efficiency, LED lights are introduced.

AFTER

2050 The date by which Hölker and others predict that, with the global population set to exceed 9 billion, Earth's total illuminated area will have doubled since 2016.

According to some ecologists, light pollution—the amount of artificially generated light in the world—could be the most damaging pollutant of all. Around 80 percent of humanity lives under skies saturated with light. In